

CHAPTER 3 — DIFFERENT

Lady Zion never remembered how the dreams began.

There was never a doorway, nor a moment when sleep became something else. One heartbeat she lay safely in her own bed, and the next she was wandering through a world so beautiful it felt older than memory, as though it had been waiting for her long before she had learned to dream.

Golden leaves drifted through the air on a wind that seemed to sing rather than blow. Crystal rivers reflected unfamiliar stars, while mountains shimmered beyond the horizon beneath a sky unlike any she had ever known. Towering trees stretched into the heavens, their branches glowing with a quiet radiance that bathed everything in warmth.

She wandered without fear, her footsteps carrying her wherever the dream wished to lead. Nothing spoke to her, yet nothing felt unfamiliar. The trees, the rivers, even the stones beneath her feet seemed quietly aware of her presence, as though they had been expecting her all along.

Tonight, however, something had changed.

The distant song she had heard since childhood was no longer carried by the wind. It surrounded her completely, gentle and welcoming, its rhythm rising and falling with the beating of her own heart. Though she could not understand its language, its meaning reached her without words.

Come.

Drawn by the melody, she followed a path of golden leaves until the forest opened before the greatest tree she had ever seen. Its immense

roots embraced the earth like living rivers, while countless luminous leaves drifted from branches that disappeared beyond the heavens.

Someone was waiting beneath it.

The figure stood motionless within the golden light. Lady Zion could not make out a face or even a clear shape, yet she felt no fear. Whoever waited beneath the great tree radiated only kindness... only patience... like someone who had been waiting for a very, very long time.

The figure slowly raised one hand. Warmth blossomed gently within her chest, and before she realized what she was doing, Lady Zion reached toward the light.

The instant her fingertips brushed a glowing leaf, the dream shattered into fragments.

A bridge of white stone.

Ancient circles carved into the earth.

A strange symbol glowing upon weathered rock.

Children laughing beneath unfamiliar skies.

Cities unlike anything she had ever imagined rose before her, their towers gleaming beneath unfamiliar skies. They appeared only for an instant before dissolving into light. She reached for them instinctively, but they slipped quietly beyond her understanding, leaving behind only faint impressions, as though someone had written upon her heart instead of her mind.

The song swelled one final time. It did not grow louder. It simply came closer until it no longer seemed to surround her, but to live within her.

Then, for the first time in all the years she had dreamed of this place, she understood.

It was calling her.

The sharp ringing of her alarm clock shattered the silence.

Lady Zion opened her eyes.

Morning sunlight spilled across her bedroom ceiling as the dream dissolved almost immediately, leaving behind only scattered fragments she could never fully remember. She already knew what would happen next. By lunchtime, even those fragments would fade, leaving behind only a strange familiarity that sometimes found its way into her drawings without her ever realizing why.

She sat quietly on the edge of her bed, one hand resting over her heart. Something had changed. She couldn't explain it, yet the world somehow felt... a little brighter.

After taking a slow breath, she reached over and silenced the alarm.

Today was her first day of high school.

"Please," she whispered with a nervous smile. "...let today be okay."

The aroma of toasted bread greeted her before she reached the kitchen. It was one of those simple routines that rarely changed. Every weekday morning, her mother prepared breakfast while humming softly to herself, and her father sat at the dining table with a cup of coffee, the newspaper folded neatly beside his plate. It was an ordinary scene, yet after a dream she could barely remember, its familiarity felt especially comforting.

"Good morning, Lady Z," her mother said, looking up from the stove with a warm smile.

"Morning, Mom."

Her father looked up from the newspaper and smiled as Lady Zion slipped quietly into her chair.

"Big day."

She nodded. "My first day."

Neither of her parents hurried the conversation. Her mother simply placed a plate of eggs and toast in front of her before returning to the stove, while her father folded the newspaper and reached for his coffee. Lady Zion thanked her automatically but sat staring at her breakfast for a moment longer than usual.

She knew she was hungry.

She simply couldn't stop thinking about the dream.

Not the dream itself. That had already begun slipping away.

Only the feeling it had left behind, as though something important had brushed against her heart before quietly disappearing again.

"You've been holding that fork for quite a while," her father said with an amused smile.

Lady Zion blinked, looked down, and laughed softly.

"I guess I have."

"Nervous?"

"A little."

"A little?" he teased. "Your breakfast is getting cold."

Her mother smiled as she poured another glass of juice.

"I think she's thinking harder than she's eating."

Lady Zion smiled sheepishly but didn't deny it.

After a comfortable silence, her father rested his elbows lightly on the table and looked at her with the calm expression she had trusted since she was little.

"You're going to meet a lot of people today," he said. "Some of them will expect everyone to think, learn, and act the same way."

Lady Zion looked up.

"You don't have to become someone else just to make other people comfortable."

The words settled quietly into her heart.

Her mother reached across the table and gently squeezed her hand.

"And whatever happens today," she said, "never let kindness be the thing you leave behind."

"I won't," Lady Zion replied, smiling.

When breakfast was over, she slipped her notebook into her backpack and walked to the front door. Just before opening the gate, she paused and looked back.

Her father stood in the doorway with one hand raised in farewell, while her mother smiled from the kitchen window.

For just a moment, Lady Zion wished she could stay exactly where she was.

Then she smiled, waved back, and stepped out into the morning.

Beyond the gate waited crowded hallways, unfamiliar faces, and a day she couldn't imagine. Drawing a slow, steady breath, Lady Zion smiled to herself before stepping out into the morning.

The neighborhood had already come alive by the time she reached the end of her street. Children in crisp uniforms hurried toward school, bicycles rattled along the sidewalks, and the familiar chorus of jeepneys, motorcycles, and impatient car horns blended into the rhythm of another ordinary weekday. People moved with quiet purpose, each carrying their own destination, each focused on arriving before the day truly began.

Lady Zion joined the steady flow of pedestrians, though her pace was noticeably slower than everyone else's—not because she wanted to be late, but because she found it difficult to ignore the countless little stories unfolding around her.

At the first intersection, the elderly crossing guard greeted every student with the same cheerful smile.

"Good morning!"

A chorus of greetings answered him before the crowd continued on. Lady Zion smiled back, but her eyes lingered on him for just a moment. His smile was genuine, yet dark circles rested beneath his eyes, and every few moments he shifted his weight from one leg to the other, his left hand drifting to the small of his back whenever he thought no one was watching.

She wondered whether he had slept well... or whether anyone had noticed.

The traffic light changed, and the crowd carried her forward. A little farther along, a toddler sat crying beside a fallen ice cream while his

mother knelt beside him, trying to calm him as people hurried past without slowing. Before Lady Zion could reach them, a nearby vendor quietly handed the little boy another cone, and his tears disappeared almost as quickly as they had come.

Lady Zion smiled.

Small kindnesses mattered.

Near the next corner, an old bicycle leaned against a weathered concrete wall. Rust covered most of its frame, and its chain had long since slipped free, yet someone had carefully tucked fresh wildflowers into the front basket that very morning. She paused for only a heartbeat before continuing on, carrying with her the quiet thought that someone still loved it enough to make it beautiful.

Just beyond the neighborhood bakery, Lady Zion noticed an elderly woman struggling beneath the weight of two grocery bags. Before she could reach the corner, one of the handles snapped, sending oranges rolling across the sidewalk.

Several people glanced over.

Then they kept walking.

Lady Zion didn't hesitate. She hurried over, knelt beside the scattered fruit, and began gathering the oranges before they could roll into the street.

"Oh, dear," the woman said, clearly embarrassed. "I'm making such a mess."

"It's okay," Lady Zion replied with a reassuring smile. "I'll help."

Together they gathered the groceries and carried them to the woman's front gate just a short distance away. As Lady Zion handed over the last

bag, the woman looked at her for a long moment before offering a smile that reached far beyond simple politeness.

"Thank you," she said softly. After a brief pause, she added, "Thank you for seeing me."

The words stayed with Lady Zion as she resumed walking. Almost absentmindedly, she glanced at the time.

Her eyes widened.

The first bell had already rung.

"Oh..."

She adjusted her backpack and broke into a hurried walk, weaving through the growing crowd as the school came into view. By the time she stepped through the front gate, the second bell was echoing across the campus.

Her heart skipped.

Students disappeared into classrooms with practiced familiarity while teachers stood outside their doors offering last-minute reminders before the morning announcements began. Conversations filled the corridors, footsteps echoed across polished floors, and lockers closed with sharp metallic clicks that blended into the familiar rhythm of another school day.

Lady Zion tightened her grip on the strap of her backpack.

I'm late.

She followed the room number printed on her class schedule until she reached the classroom near the end of the hallway. The door already stood open, and inside, the teacher was taking attendance.

Lady Zion paused outside, drew one steadying breath, and knocked gently.

"I'm... sorry I'm late."

Every head turned toward her.

The room suddenly felt much smaller.

For most students, it might have been nothing more than an awkward moment.

For Lady Zion, it became a flood of sensations arriving all at once.

The fluorescent lights hummed overhead with a faint, unbroken vibration. Chairs scraped across the floor as students turned to look at her. Pens clicked. Someone whispered. A page rustled near the windows while the ceiling fan spun above with a rhythmic ticking she hadn't noticed from the hallway.

None of the sounds were loud.

Together, they became too much.

Every face seemed to be looking at her. Every passing second stretched just a little longer than it should have. A hundred thoughts rushed through her mind at once. Should she apologize again? Explain why she was late? Turn around and leave before everyone noticed how frightened she felt?

Instead, her fingers found the worn edge of the notebook tucked beneath her arm.

She traced the familiar cover with her thumb and drew one slow breath, then another. Gradually the sounds around her untangled, no longer crashing together into one impossible wave. The lights still hummed.

The fan still ticked. Voices still drifted through the room. But now they were separate again, and she could breathe.

When she finally looked up, the teacher was smiling.

"I'm glad you made it, Lady Zion."

The warmth in her voice softened something inside the room.

"There's an empty seat by the window. Please make yourself comfortable."

The whispers faded as quickly as they had begun, and the lesson quietly resumed. Lady Zion walked to the empty desk, placed her notebook carefully in the corner, and sat down without drawing any more attention to herself.

No one realized the battle she had just fought.

But she did.

For today, that quiet victory was enough.

By lunchtime, the classroom no longer felt quite so unfamiliar. The morning's introductions had given way to easy conversations as classmates compared their old schools, discovered shared interests, and laughed over stories that only they seemed to understand. Small circles of friendship formed almost effortlessly, as though everyone instinctively knew where they belonged.

Lady Zion watched quietly from her seat. She wasn't lonely—not really. She simply never seemed to find the right moment to step into conversations that were already moving faster than her thoughts.

As her classmates gathered their lunches, her attention drifted toward the far side of the classroom, where a girl sat alone beside the window.

Unlike everyone else, she never seemed to hurry. She packed her books with quiet care, waited until the doorway had cleared, and slipped into the hallway without brushing against anyone. There was nothing unfriendly about her movements. If anything, they seemed almost... careful.

A few students noticed her leave.

"There she goes again," one boy muttered.

"My cousin says she's always like that."

"I don't think she likes anybody."

The comments drifted through the room as casually as the laughter around them, repeated so often they no longer sounded unkind. Lady Zion looked from the doorway to the empty chair beside the window, trying to understand what the others had seen. People who disliked others usually looked impatient, irritated, or simply uninterested.

She had seen none of those things.

She had seen someone who looked alone.

The thought stayed with her long enough that she found herself following the girl into the hallway. When she finally caught up, the words she had practiced disappeared the moment the girl turned to face her. Lady Zion's eyes settled instead on the notebook tucked beneath her arm.

"I..." She offered an awkward smile. "...I like your notebook."

The girl blinked once before looking down at its plain blue cover. For a moment she seemed genuinely surprised, as though no one had ever noticed something so ordinary.

"Thank you."

Silence settled between them, not uncomfortable, only uncertain. Lady Zion could almost hear herself searching for the words she had meant to say, but they refused to come.

That wasn't what I meant to say.

She laughed softly, more at herself than anything else.

"I'll... see you later."

The girl nodded politely before continuing toward the cafeteria. Lady Zion remained where she was for a few moments, watching her disappear into the crowd before turning back toward her own classroom.

Why is talking so much harder than noticing?

The cafeteria was louder than the classroom.

Instead of searching for a crowded table, Lady Zion found an empty bench beside a large window overlooking the school garden. The sunlight spilling through the glass softened the noise just enough that she could finally relax.

The girl from the hallway paused beside the table, glanced around the crowded cafeteria, then quietly took the empty seat across from Lady Zion. She never asked whether the seat was taken. Somehow, she simply seemed to know it wasn't.

For a while, neither of them spoke. Around them the cafeteria buzzed with laughter, conversations, and the clatter of trays, yet the silence between them never felt awkward. If anything, it felt unexpectedly

comfortable, as though neither of them expected the other to become someone different just to keep the conversation alive.

Several minutes passed before the girl finally looked up.

"You're not very talkative."

Lady Zion smiled.

"Neither are you."

For the first time that day, they both laughed. It wasn't loud enough for anyone else to notice, but neither of them seemed to mind. Some friendships begin with endless conversations. Theirs began with a quiet understanding that silence could be shared just as easily as words.

By the time lunch was over, the afternoon no longer felt quite so unfamiliar.

The introductions were over, and the classroom gradually settled into a comfortable rhythm. Teachers explained class expectations, students organized their schedules, and the nervous energy that had filled the room since sunrise slowly gave way to quiet familiarity.

Lady Zion spent the rest of the afternoon listening more than speaking. Every so often, her attention wandered toward the girl by the window. Once, their eyes met across the classroom, and the girl answered with the faintest of smiles before returning to her notes.

Lady Zion smiled back.

It wasn't much, but for the first time that day, the classroom no longer felt quite so unfamiliar.

When the final bell rang, chairs scraped across the floor as students hurried to pack their bags. Conversations quickly filled the room again, everyone eager to begin the journey home.

The girl by the window paused beside Lady Zion's desk as the last of the students gathered their things.

"Lunch tomorrow?"

Lady Zion looked up, caught off guard by the invitation. A smile slowly spread across her face.

"I'd like that."

"Good."

The girl gave a small wave before disappearing into the steady stream of students flowing through the classroom door.

Lady Zion slipped her notebook into her backpack, still smiling to herself, when she heard a familiar voice behind her.

"Lady Zion?"

She turned to find her homeroom teacher standing beside the desk, wearing the same warm smile that had welcomed her that morning.

"Would you stay for just a moment?"

"Yes, ma'am."

Within minutes, the classroom emptied until only the two of them remained. Afternoon sunlight poured through the windows, replacing the soft hum of fluorescent lights with the golden warmth of late day. Without dozens of overlapping conversations, the room felt wonderfully peaceful.

The teacher leaned lightly against the desk, waiting until the last of the students had disappeared into the hallway.

"I've been thinking about something that happened during lunch."

Lady Zion looked up. The teacher smiled gently.

"The girl by the window. What made you walk after her?"

Lady Zion blinked, surprised by the question.

"I... I don't know."

"Most students think she keeps to herself because she doesn't like people," the teacher said. "But you didn't."

Lady Zion lowered her eyes, turning the question over in her mind. Finding the right words was never easy, especially when the answer was something she had simply felt rather than understood.

"I didn't think she was angry."

The teacher remained silent, allowing the thought to settle before asking quietly, "What did you think?"

Lady Zion traced the worn edge of her notebook with her thumb.

"I thought..." She hesitated, searching for words that felt true. "...she was trying very hard not to be in everyone's way. She looked lonely."

Silence settled over the classroom. The teacher's expression changed almost imperceptibly—not with surprise, but with recognition. Without saying anything, she reached for the small notebook resting on her desk, opened it, and quietly wrote a single sentence.

Lady Zion couldn't see what she had written.

When the notebook closed again, the teacher looked up and smiled.

"Thank you."

Lady Zion tilted her head, puzzled.

"For what?"

"For noticing."

The answer stayed with her long after she left the classroom. She couldn't understand why such an ordinary observation had seemed so important, yet the quiet gratitude in her teacher's voice made her feel she had somehow seen something other people had missed.

The walk home felt different.

The streets were the same ones Lady Zion had traveled that morning. The same crossing guard stood at the intersection, still smiling despite the long day. The same neighborhood bakery filled the air with the scent of fresh bread, and children chased one another through the small park as parents called them home before sunset.

Nothing around her had changed, yet somehow the world felt a little lighter.

As she reached the intersection, the elderly crossing guard greeted her with the same cheerful smile he had worn that morning.

"Good afternoon."

"Good afternoon," Lady Zion replied.

"First day?"

She nodded. "It went better than I expected."

"I'm glad to hear that."

Lady Zion continued walking, the conversation fading behind her as the events of the day quietly replayed in her thoughts. She remembered arriving late, the rush of panic when every eye had turned toward her, the awkward conversation in the hallway, and the quiet lunch she had never expected to share. Strangely, it wasn't the difficult moments that stayed with her. It was a quiet laugh, a teacher's unexpected question, and a simple invitation.

"Lunch tomorrow?"

Lady Zion smiled to herself. Maybe tomorrow wouldn't feel quite so unfamiliar after all.

By the time she reached home, the afternoon sun had begun slipping behind the neighboring rooftops. She greeted her parents, changed out of her school uniform, and settled into the familiar rhythm of homework before dinner. Mathematics gave way to literature, literature to science, and before long her assignments were neatly completed.

Only then did she reach for the notebook she carried everywhere.

She stepped into the backyard and settled onto the old wooden bench beside the small garden. It had become her favorite place to think whenever the world felt too noisy.

The evening breeze stirred gently through the trees as Lady Zion opened her notebook to a blank page. At first, she meant to sketch the old bicycle she had seen that morning, but before she realized it, her pencil had begun moving somewhere else entirely.

"I wasn't going to draw that..."

Yet her hand continued across the page as though it already knew where each line belonged.

The first lines curved upward almost effortlessly, tracing the trunk of an enormous tree unlike any she had ever seen. Lady Zion frowned and stopped drawing. The pencil rested motionless in her fingers as she stared at the unfinished sketch, trying to understand how it had appeared on the page.

"That's not what I was drawing," she murmured with a quiet, puzzled smile.

Shaking her head, she turned to a fresh page, determined to begin again. This time she didn't even have the chance to make the first line. The pencil moved before she did, gliding across the paper with calm, deliberate strokes as though it already knew where it was going.

The great tree returned.

Its roots spread beneath the earth like living rivers, while branches climbed so high they disappeared beyond the edge of the paper. Tiny leaves drifted around its crown, each one catching the light with a faint radiance her pencil had no right to capture.

Lady Zion's breathing slowed. The drawing didn't feel imagined. It felt remembered, though she couldn't have said why. Before she could question the thought, the pencil continued moving across the page.

A white stone bridge emerged beneath the tree, stretching across a river that reflected unfamiliar stars. Beyond it rose mountains unlike any she had seen in books or photographs. Near the bridge stood great circles of weathered stone, arranged with such careful purpose that they seemed to be waiting for someone.

Then the pencil hesitated. Its movement slowed almost imperceptibly before drifting toward the center of the page, where it traced a strange symbol. A perfect circle emerged first, followed by graceful lines that intertwined with quiet precision, flowing as naturally as though they had been written countless times before.

Lady Zion's hand froze, and her fingers slowly loosened around the pencil until it rolled gently across the bench. She stared at the drawing without moving.

"I've never..." Her voice faltered. "...I've never seen this place."

She searched her memory, but nothing answered. No storybook, no movie, no lesson at school could explain why the tree, the bridge, the mountains, and now this mysterious symbol all felt so deeply familiar. They should have belonged to a stranger's imagination. Instead, they stirred a longing she couldn't explain, as though they had once been part of her life before slipping beyond memory.

She should have been frightened, but she wasn't. The feeling that settled over her was closer to homesickness—not for her house or anywhere she had ever lived, but for somewhere she couldn't remember.

Carefully, she closed the notebook against her chest.

"I'm keeping you," she whispered, smiling faintly at the strange thought.

At that moment, the evening breeze stirred through the garden once more. The notebook slipped open beneath her hands, its pages fluttering rapidly until they stopped at the drawing. A single golden leaf drifted silently onto the paper, glowing softly for the briefest heartbeat before becoming perfectly still.

Lady Zion looked up at the old mango tree swaying gently overhead. Every leaf upon its branches was perfectly ordinary—green, sunlit, and stirred only by the evening wind. Slowly she lowered her gaze again.

The golden leaf was still there.

By the time the evening sky had deepened into blue, the house had settled into its familiar rhythm.

The aroma of dinner drifted from the kitchen while soft conversation filled the dining room. Her father spoke about work, her mother shared stories from the neighborhood, and every so often they asked Lady Zion about her first day.

"So..." her father said with a smile over his bowl of soup. "Will tomorrow be easier?"

Lady Zion thought for a moment before answering. "I think so."

"Made any friends?"

She smiled as the quiet girl by the window came to mind.

"...Maybe."

Her parents exchanged a knowing glance, and her mother's smile softened.

"Maybe is a good beginning."

Lady Zion smiled back. She liked that answer more than she expected.

After dinner, she helped her mother wash the dishes, packed her books for the next day, and changed into her pajamas. The house gradually settled into its familiar evening rhythm, comforting in the way only home could be. Before climbing into bed, she reached for the notebook once more.

The strange drawing was exactly where she had left it.

The great tree still stretched across the page, its luminous branches sheltering the white bridge, the unfamiliar mountains, and the ancient

stone circles. At the center of it all rested the strange symbol, drawn with a confidence she still couldn't understand.

The golden leaf remained where it had fallen. Lady Zion reached out and gently touched it with the tip of one finger. It felt no different from any ordinary leaf, dry and delicate beneath her hand, yet something deep within her quietly insisted that it didn't belong to this world.

She closed the notebook with quiet care and placed it on the small table beside her bed.

"Good night," she whispered, though she wasn't sure whether she was speaking to herself... or to the strange place she could no longer remember.

Within minutes, sleep quietly found her. Moonlight slipped through the bedroom window and settled softly upon the notebook resting beside her bed.

Hidden beneath its cover, the mysterious symbol shimmered with a faint silver light, so briefly that anyone watching might have mistaken it for a trick of the moon.

Then the room became still once more.

Far beyond Earth's skies, beyond the stars Lady Zion had gazed upon since childhood, an ancient sanctuary rested beneath the night of Zionara. Its weathered stones had watched a thousand years pass in silence, while towering pillars carved by forgotten hands encircled a quiet courtyard. Above them, countless luminous leaves drifted from a great tree whose branches reached toward the heavens.

At the heart of the sanctuary stood a solitary stone altar. Carved into its ancient surface was the same mysterious symbol that now lay hidden within Lady Zion's notebook.

Without warning, the symbol began to glow. At first the light was faint, little more than a silver ember beneath the stone. Then it slowly brightened—not with power, but with recognition, as though answering a call that had crossed the distance between two worlds.

An elderly Steward, seated alone in silent prayer, slowly opened his eyes. His gaze settled upon the altar, and a gentle smile touched his weathered face. He spoke no words. None were needed.

Far above the sanctuary, a single luminous leaf broke free from the great tree and drifted into the night, carried upon a wind that crossed kingdoms, mountains, and seas.

The Calling had begun.

Neither Lady Zion nor the ancient world waiting beyond her dreams yet understood what that would mean.

But the path set in motion that night would one day change them both forever.